Distinctly Decatur

Comprehensive Land Use Plan
Decatur, GA

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Intro to Land Use
CP 6112

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Introduction

Decatur, Georgia is an independent city located in DeKalb County. To the west and south of the city, Decatur borders the city of Atlanta. To the east it borders Avondale Estates, and the rest of the city is bordered by unincorporated DeKalb County. Decatur has historically benefited from its location, as residents were able to travel quickly to and from Atlanta; first by streetcar and later by automobiles and MARTA. While walking around the city, it is easy to see how its history has influenced its character and, but it is also clear that the city is taking an active role in shaping the current land use patterns of the city (City of Decatur).

When traveling to Decatur by MARTA's Blue Line, one of the first things a visitor notices is the MARTA station itself. Most of the other Blue Line stations located in DeKalb County can be characterized by park-and-ride lots and their location along freight rail alignments. However, Decatur Station is different. It has no designated parking lot and is located directly under the densest and most walkable part of the city. Upon exiting the station, it is easy to notice the abundance of shops, restaurants, and apartments directly adjacent to or within a few minutes' walk from the station. A large bus hub connects riders to further destinations, and bike lanes line the main thoroughfares.

However, one does not have to walk far to find that these land use patterns are rather limited in their geographic extent. If a visitor walks just a few blocks away from the station in any direction, they will quickly encounter single-family homes, wide roads such as Commerce Drive and Clairemont Avenue, and gas stations and surface parking lots. However, Downtown Decatur is not the only area in the city where it is possible to find walkable neighborhoods and denser housing.

In the south part of the city, the historic neighborhood of Oakhurst features dense single-family development interspersed with apartments and townhomes. Residents can walk to shops, restaurants, and schools in the neighborhood, and some have easy access to East Lake Station, Decatur's second MARTA rail station. East Decatur is home to newer mixed-use developments that have been connected to Avondale Station.

Demographics

The nature of Decatur can be better understood through its demographics. Comparing US Census data from 1980 and 2020 excellently illustrates the primary demographic changes in Decatur and provides essential context on its current land use and other existing conditions. These years in particular illuminate unique racial and socioeconomic trends and provide insight into family makeup over this significant period. Each of these demographics' have both contributed and responded to Decatur's landscape over the years and influenced its land use patterns through the city's expression of cultural values and priorities, evident in the city's emphasis on walkability to educational facilities and transportation.

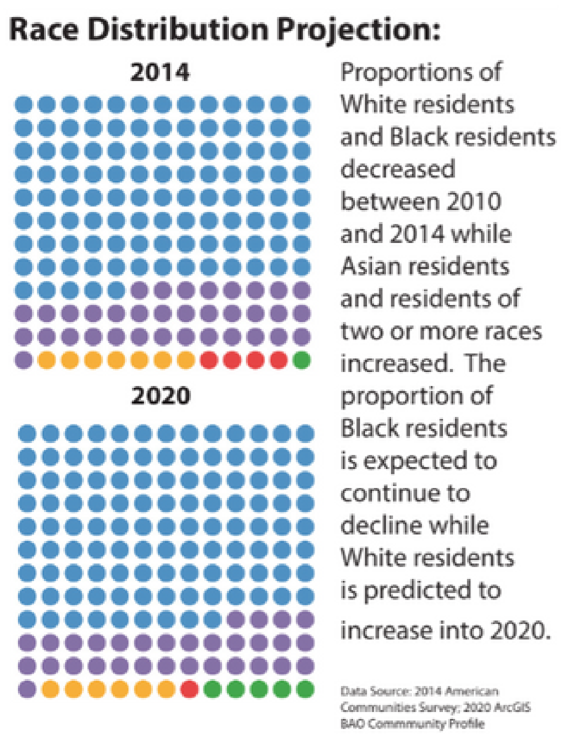
Additionally, comparing demographic projections from the City of Decatur Comprehensive Plan Update in 2016 to actual 2020 US Census data provide insight on the current rate of racial, age and socioeconomic (household income) change. Decatur's demographic changes over a more limited and recent timeframe will inevitably influence future land use patterns, potentially amplifying or undermining the trends we observed. Decatur's demographics reveal that it is a wealthy, family-oriented, and increasingly racially heterogenous community.

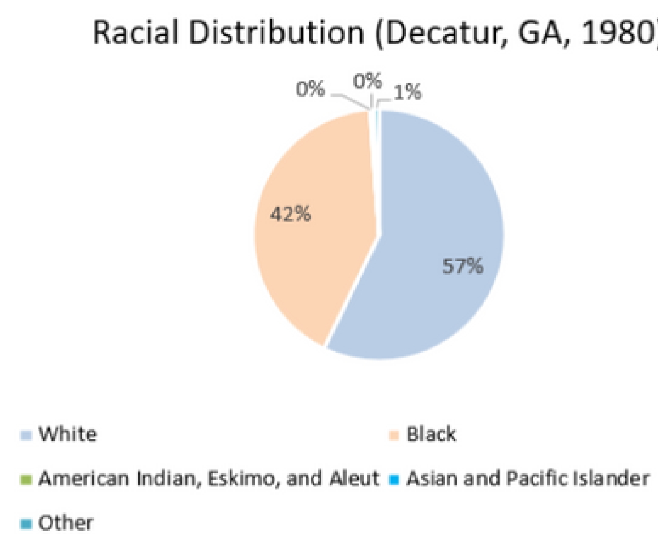
The population of Decatur in 1980 was 18,404 people. That has increased by 35.45% to 24,928 residents in 2020.

Racial Makeup

The population of Black residents in Decatur was 7,666, which was nearly half of the population, or 41.7%. The White residents were the majority at 10,527 individuals, or 57.2%. Other racial categories that were considered in the 1980 Census ('American Indian, Eskimo and Aleut,' 'Asian and Pacific Islanders,' and 'Other') represented a negligible portion of the population, at 1.2% of the population total.

These racial trends illustrate that Decatur was a relatively racially diverse suburb in the greater Atlanta metro region in 1980 with a relatively equal distribution of White and Black residents.





Figures 1 & 2

The 2020 US Census data represent slightly different trends. There are more racial categories included in the 2020 analysis, but comparing previous categories indicated in the 1980 census, we see that the White population ('Non-Hispanic White Alone') is 67.38% and 16,796 individuals, the Black population is 15.4% and 3,839 individuals, Hispanic is 1,294 individuals or 5.19%, and Other is 153 individuals, or 0.6% of the population. This shows an alarming 26.3% decrease in the Black population from 1980 to 2020 and a 10.18% increase in the White population over the same time frame. This confirms the city's 2016 Comprehensive Plan race projection.

Age Distribution

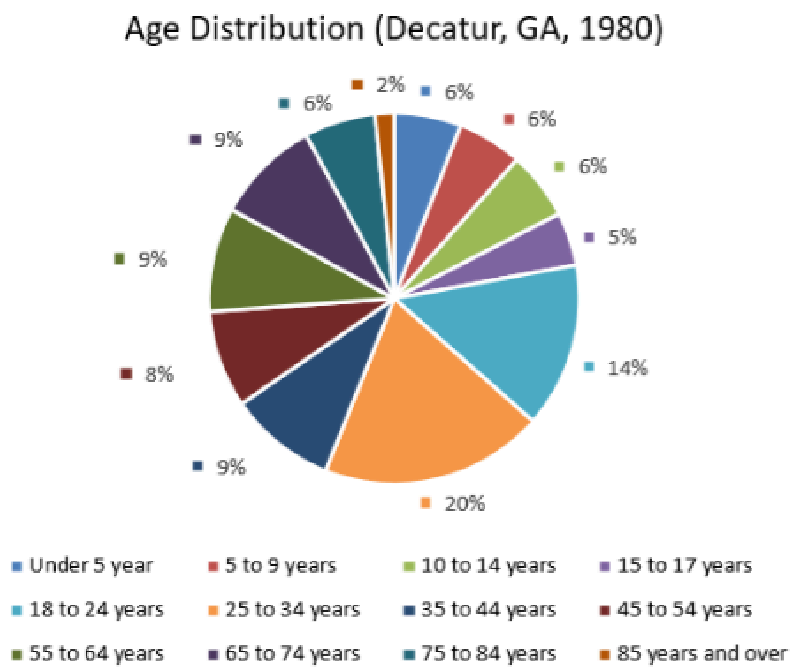


Figure 3

According to the data by the 2020 US Census, we can see that most Decatur's inhabitants were aged 25-24 (19.5%), with the 18–24-year-old demographic following closely behind (14.4%). However, we do see that there are lots of working adults in the area, with the total percentage of citizens aged 35 to 75 comprising 36.2% of the population. Additionally, children, which we define as individuals aged 18 and below, make up 22.1% of the population. These statistics reveal that 58.1% of the population was either in the working-age population or a child. This aligns with the historic nature of Decatur as a commuter city – hence the concentration of working-aged individuals – and being a suburban family haven.

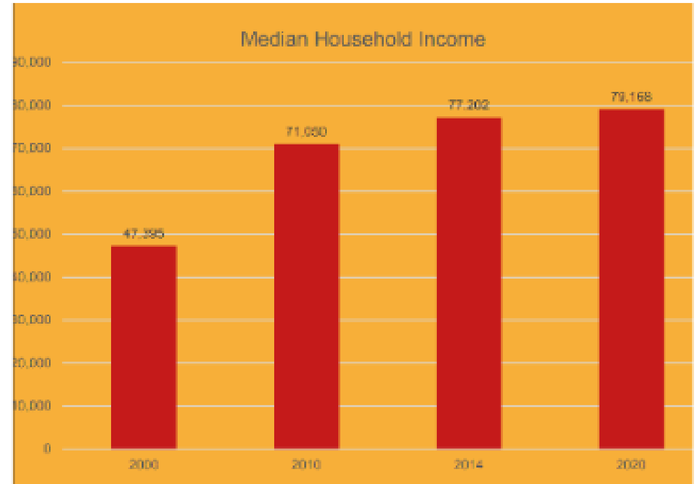
The City of Decatur's 2016 Comprehensive Plan Update projected that the proportion of children and seniors would increase. From the 2020 US Census data, we can observe that the proportion of individuals under 18 years old comprised 24.38%, whereas adults (18 and over) made up 71.63% of the population. There has been a 6.27% increase in the proportion of children in the city, which confirms the city's emphasis on accessibility to educational institutions in their current land use.

Economic Profile

Economically, the median household income in Decatur according to the 1980 Census was $45,574 (adjusted to 2020 dollars). In the context of the region, Atlanta's adjusted household income was $37,640, and the average adjusted US household income was $56,117. Thus, we can see that Decatur was generally on-par with regional income levels, and below national income levels.

Due to current gaps in accessing US Census data, pulling from the American Community Survey (ACS) 2022, we see that Decatur's median household income was $129,992. According to the city, the projected income for 2020 would be $79,168 (City of Decatur, 2016). Although we are comparing 2020 and 2022 data, it is clear that the actual median income has far surpassed the projected statistics.

Decatur is an affluent community with a concentration of high-income households.



Median Household Income in Decatur has risen significantly since 2000 and is projected to continue to rise into the future.

Figure 4

Zoning in Decatur, Georgia

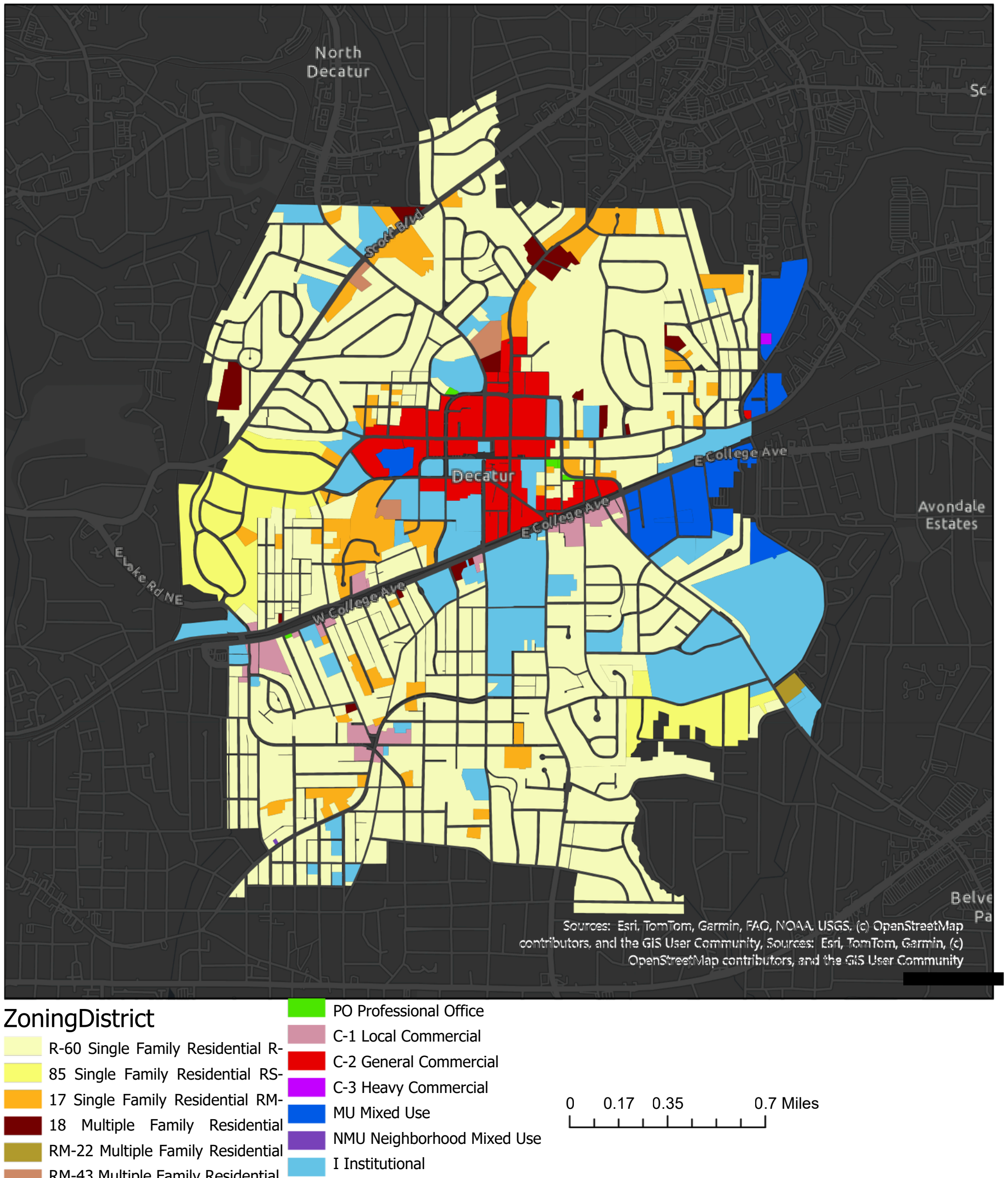


Figure 5

Land Use

The current land use of Decatur is defined by its municipal zoning. Decatur can be separated into six broad scale categories: Single-family, multiple-family, office, commercial, mixed-use, and institutional. Single, multi-family, mixed-use, and commercial zoning can be separated into smaller respective categories displayed in Figure 5. The data is provided directly by the City of Decatur and follows their municipally defined zoning and land-use criteria.

From this map, we can divide the city into seven distinct regions: Central/Downtown, Northwest, Northeast, Southwest, South, West, and East. In the Central/Downtown core, the zoning is primarily commercial and institutional. In the Northwest and Northeast, most of the zoning is designated for single family housing. Southwest, the zoning is primarily single-family zoning with a central commercial zone. The South is generally single-family and institutional zoning. The West is single-family mixed zoning. Finally, the East is primarily institutional zoning, as within this region lies Agnes Scott College.

Overall, most of the city is single-family zoned while institutional and commercial zones are focused in the Central/Downtown and East region. There is some mixed-use development and very little office zoning. No part of Decatur is zoned for industrial use, which speaks to its highly residential and suburban nature. Notably, the road layout is also different throughout the city, with the Central/Downtown region following a grid, that is quickly abandoned as the city expands beyond its central core.

Walkability

Beyond general zoning and existing land-use, a walkability analysis was conducted based off of identified POIs. These POIs were selected through site visits to Decatur and for their relevance to the overall livability of the community. Walkability analysis was produced utilizing the city's sidewalk network, with the city limits as boundary analysis. There is a distinct lack of grocery stores, a notable presence of educational institutions, and various MARTA stations.

This walking distance map is divided into POIs based on educational facilities provided by the City of Decatur. These POIs include primary and secondary schools, colleges, recreational centers, libraries, and any other general educational facilities. This map illustrates five-, 10-, and 15-minute margins walking towards the POIs, revealing that most of Decatur is within walking distance of educational intuitions. The Northeastern region of Decatur is an exception to this accessibility, however. The impressive access to educational facilities depicts the effort Decatur has put into the land use planning centered on walkability and education. Decatur has also shaped its land use towards accessibility.

Additionally, several educational sites have varying levels of land use impact. The most notable aspect of educational facilities were the libraries in Downtown Decatur, which provided the community access to local history, a law library, volunteer library, and county library. These amenities were all central to the city and located well within walking corridors. There were also libraries at the Agnes Scott College and small "Little Free" libraries within the southern part of the city that were not listed as POIs.

Decatur has a heavy land use pattern linked to access to education, with a specific focus on book accessibility.

Walking Distance To Education Facilities in Minutes

Decatur, GA

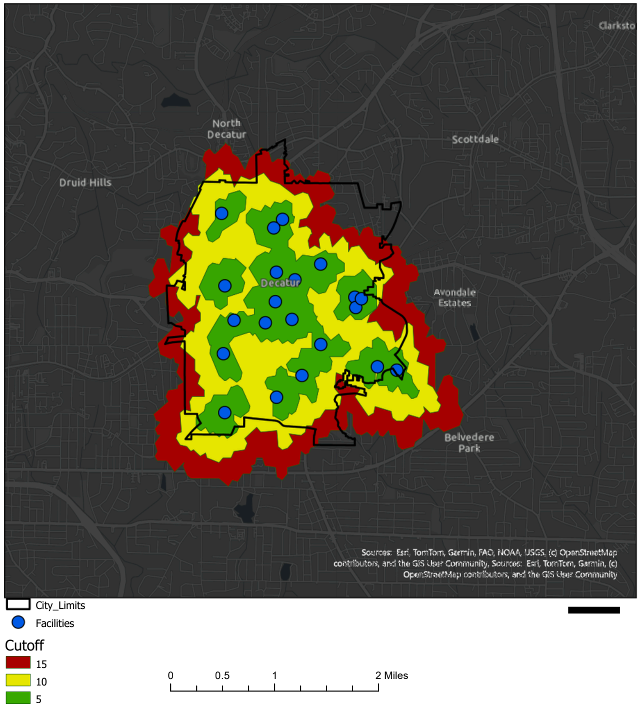
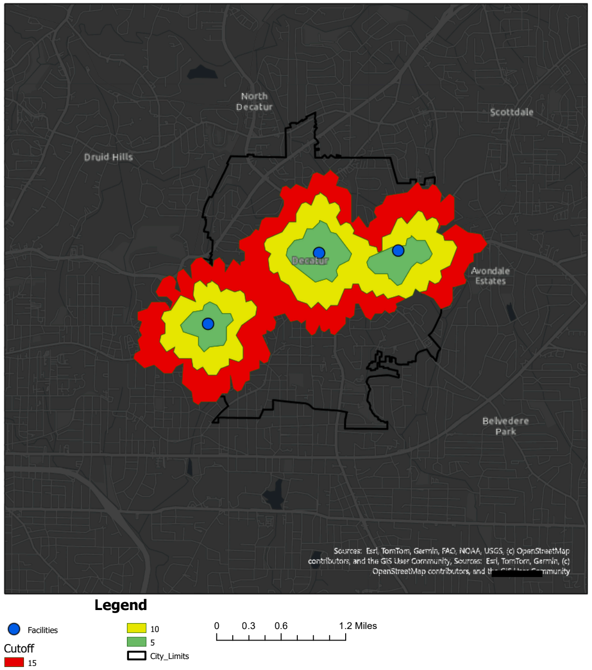


Figure 6

Walk Time To MARTA Stations in Minutes

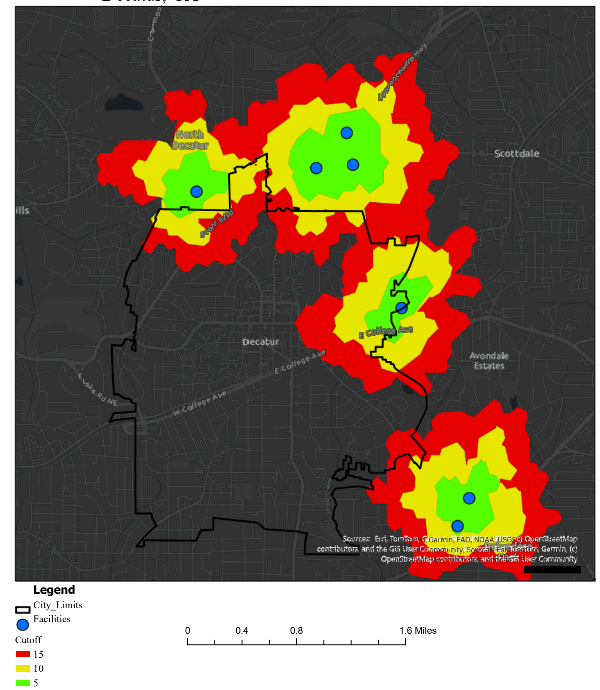
Decatur, GA



Figures 7 & 8

Walking Distance To Grocery Stores in Minutes

Decatur, GA



This walkability distance map focuses on walking distance to grocery stores. These POIs were determined by their relative closeness to the city's boundary. Notably, there is only one grocery location that is partially inside the city boundary. The POIs selected for representation are large-scale grocery stores. For example, Savi Provisions, a local specialty food shop, was excluded from identified POIs.

It is evident that Decatur's access to grocery stores on foot is highly lacking. A small portion of the city has access within 5- or 10- minutes walking, but most residents are located 15 minutes or more from significant grocery services. Furthermore, the only store located in the city boundaries is the only grocery store that is located adjacent to a MARTA station.

Decatur has not utilized their land use pattern towards food access. In turn, Decatur could be considered a food desert.

This walking distance map examines the walking distance to Metropolitan Atlanta Rapid Transit Authority (MARTA) stations within the city. MARTA is multimodal public transportation that provides Decatur with two train stops and central bus stop, all of which are listed as MARTA POIs.

Decatur could be considered to have low walkability scores for transit. Most of the city is greater than 15-minutes walking distance from a MARTA station while commercial and mixed-use zoning are the primary zones within the five-minute walking boundary. MARTA stations have a particularly large footprint, specifically Decatur Station. With consideration of the zoning around the stations, it is clear that the city has put forth efforts to prioritize transit-oriented development.

However, most of the zoning around the East Lake Station and Avondale Station is single family or institutional. Overall, the city seems to focus less on transit-oriented land development.

Trend Analysis

The City of Decatur’s land use is best analyzed with three interconnected dimensions of activity: traffic, pedestrian/cyclist, and street design. Street design significantly affects the flow of traffic and consequently the walkability and bike ability of an area. Auto-centric design versus pedestrian-centric design speaks to the degree of Decatur's success with their intended land use and how effective the zoning and aspirational designations have been.

Two site visits provided the data to produce a thorough understanding of Decatur’s pedestrian/cyclist and car activity. The first site visit was on a Thursday from roughly 5:30-8:30 p.m. This time was selected to observe rush hour traffic, individuals dining downtown, and potential foot traffic as people walk dogs or engage in exercise in the evenings after work, and to observe how activity changed as the sun set. The conditions for this visit were cold, windy, and overcast.

The second site visit was on a Sunday morning from 10:30 a.m.-1 p.m. General weekend activity and reflected the potential influence that Sunday morning church was observed on patterns of behavior. The conditions on this day were sunny and warm. Any discrepancies in data, specifically in regard to pedestrian/cyclist activity, are likely a result of weather. Traffic data from both site visits should not be impacted by weather conditions.

Each metric is based on a Likert scale of low, medium, and high activity. Each definition of these metrics is based on the measure variable. For example, the low measurement for traffic volume is anything less than 15 cars at a given intersection. This is the general theme for numeric indicators for all data collected, and each scale is specified within the respective sections that follow. All our data and POIs summarized in Figure 9.

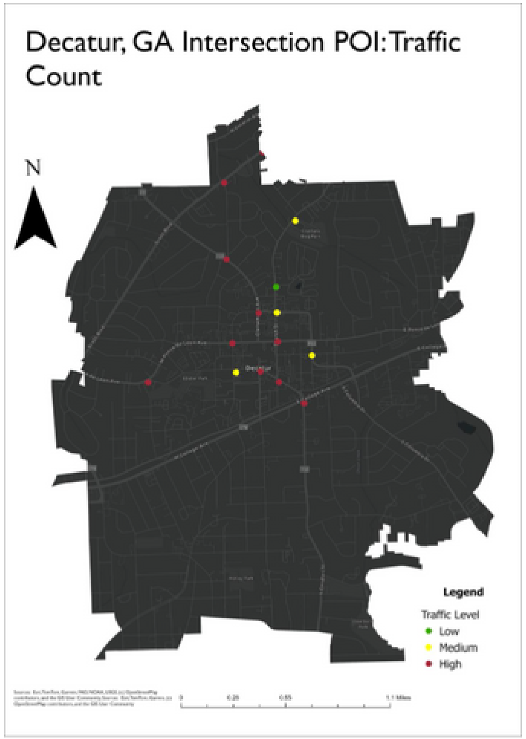
Location	X_Longitude_DD	Y_Latitude_DD	Traffic Level	Pedestrian Activity	Bike Level	Transit Level	Buidling Intensity
Commerce Dr & Clairemont Ave	-84.296389	33.777778	3	1	1	1	3
Commerce Dr & East Ponce de Leon Ave	-84.298889	33.775556	3	2	1	2	3
West Trinity Pl & Commerce Dr	-84.298611	33.773333	2	1	1	2	3
West Trinity Pl & North McDonough St	-84.296389	33.773333	3	2	1	1	2
East Trinity Pl & Church St	-84.294722	33.7725	3	2	1	2	2
East Trinity Pl & East College Ave	-84.2925	33.770833	3	1	2	2	2
Sycamore St & Commerce Dr	-84.291667	33.774444	2	2	1	1	1
East Ponde de Leon Ave & Church St	-84.294722	33.775556	3	3	1	1	3
Commerce Dr & Church St	-84.294722	33.777778	2	1	1	1	1
Church St & Bell St	-84.294722	33.779722	1	1	1	2	1
Church St & Norris St	-84.292778	33.784722	2	1	1	1	1
Willow Ln & Highway 29	-84.295556	33.79	3	1	1	1	1
Highway 29 & Superior Ave	-84.299167	33.787778	3	1	1	1	1
Michigan Ave & Clairmont Ave	-84.299167	33.781944	3	1	1	1	1
West Ponce de Leon Ave & West Trinity Pl	-84.306667	33.772778	3	1	2	1	2

Figure 9

Overall, Decatur is a city with high pedestrian and vehicle activity with low to moderate cyclist activity. However, pedestrian activity is most concentrated in the center of the city near the densest development, whereas vehicle activity is relatively high throughout the city, with particular intersections facing more congested than others due to location, design, or capacity limitations. There is an observed difference in the correlation between the different variables we measured. The strongest positive correlation was between Traffic Level and Building Intensity, whereas the weakest negative correlation was between Bike Level and Pedestrian Activity. The city is filled with car and pedestrian activity, specifically downtown. There is also evidence that certain land uses, such as high-density buildings, increase both vehicle and pedestrian volume.

Correlation Matrix	Traffic Level	Pedestrian Activity	Bike Level	Transit Level	Building Intensity
Traffic Level	1	0.2895	0.281	-0.2052	0.4328
Pedestrian Activity	0.2895	1	-0.281	-0.0342	0.3934
Bike Level	0.281	-0.281	1	0.1217	0.07
Transit Level	-0.2052	-0.0342	0.1217	1	0.3068
Building Intensity	0.4328	0.3934	0.07	0.3068	1

Figure 10



Figures 11 &12

Traffic Analysis

The traffic in Decatur varies in different regions of the city. The analysis examined select intersections identified through site visits, ranging from downtown Decatur to the northern limits of the city. Figure 11 illustrates the traffic volume at each identified intersection. Low traffic count is less than 15 cars at the given intersection. Medium traffic volume is between 15-25 cars at the intersection. Lastly, high traffic volume is greater than 25 cars at the intersection. The data shows a heavy car centric system through downtown and the western observed intersections. The neighborhoods north of downtown had less traffic and were overall were more pedestrian friendly.

The intersection with the most observed traffic was Commerce Drive and Clairemont Avenue. This intersection has two lanes, westbound and eastbound along Commerce Drive, each with a left turn lane. Each direction also has two lanes, one for through traffic and one for through/ right turn traffic. These lanes also feature a bike lane crossing. The southbound direction of Clairemont Avenue has two left turn lanes and a right/through lane. The northbound direction of Clairemont Avenue has one left turn lane and one through/right turn lane. Notably the left turn lane towards northbound Clairemont Avenue was backed up for over 300 feet and held more than 20 cars. Overall, this intersection contained the most observed traffic and car volume.

The intersections with the most traffic congestion also have higher observed building intensity. Our metrics for low building intensity were intersections with buildings averaging less than three stories of building height. Medium is identified as intersections with buildings averaging 3-6 stories. High is identified as intersections with buildings averaging greater than six stories. A correlation matrix identifies a moderate positive correlation (0.43) between building intensity increasing and traffic volume increasing at any given intersection.

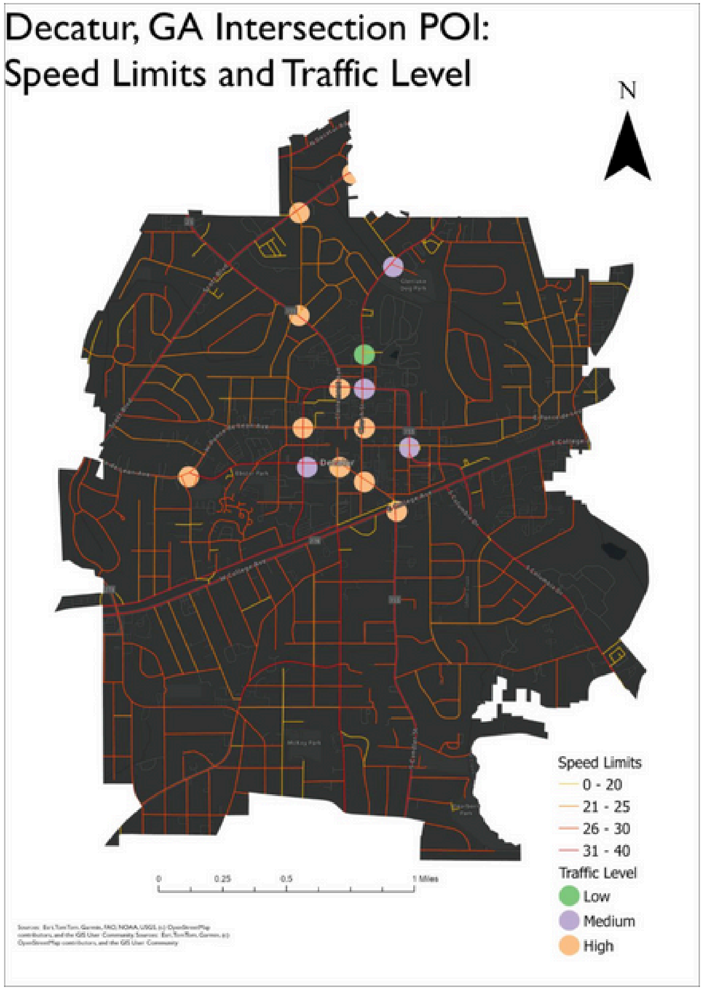


Figure 13

The city boasts a variety of traffic speeds on numerous routes. Figure 13 represents the street speed limits within the scope of intersection POI locations. We found that many of the higher traffic volume intersections did have higher speeds. Notably, these are based on posted speed limits, which may not represent the speed at which individuals actually drive. For example, most vehicles at northern intersections were observed to have higher speeds than the posted speed limits. This can be further explained through the design of the road.

Overall, the traffic in Decatur has some patterns in the building density and central location linked to volume. We also observed that the traffic volume can increase due to turning lane clogs or road closures. Decatur can be generally said to be a car centric community, as seen in the data and observations.

Pedestrian & Cyclist Analysis

Overall, pedestrian and cyclist activity varied highly across Decatur, with most pedestrian activity concentrated near the city center and cyclist activity being generally low and dispersed across our points of interest. Intersections were a significant site for data collection because pedestrian use is funneled to crosswalks, and the quality of crosswalks and perceived safety of intersections directly impacts the walkability of an area. Pedestrian activity is defined as being the number of pedestrians at any given point or intersection. Specifically, low pedestrian activity is 10 or less pedestrians. Medium pedestrian activity is 10-25 pedestrians and high pedestrian activity is 25 or greater pedestrians.

The city center, which was defined as the area contained within E. Ponce de Leon Avenue, Church Street, E./W. Trinity Place and Commerce Drive, different levels of activity were observed across site visits, but the same relative trends were represented. The central area was analyzed on two occasions to gain a more accurate depiction of pedestrian use in Decatur's central plaza. During the first site visit, there were relatively few people out, most of whom were adults. Many small businesses around Decatur Square close at 5-6:00 p.m. and although there are several restaurants, pubs and fast-food establishments, there was very little available infrastructure for people on the weeknight, families in particular. In Decatur Square and the barrier streets, medium pedestrian activity was observed, mostly near dining.

However, during the second site visit high pedestrian activity was recorded in the same areas. There were families with small children playing running around the plaza, a line out of the door for a coffee shop on the square, a photoshoot on the steps of the county courthouse and countless other groups of people window-shopping, walking dogs, or dining. There was also a Fall Festival that attracted many families. Across site visits, this POI boasts the highest pedestrian activity and presence of children in the city.

The land use and urban design of Decatur's center lend itself well to pedestrian use due to its well-marked crosswalks, maintained sidewalks, tree-lined streets, mixed-use zoning and availability of commercial amenities for all demographics. It appears that the city center is a well-utilized pedestrian hub that is continuing to improve accessibility as it is currently constructing a Hillside Play Area in Decatur Square.

Figure 14

For cyclists, levels of bike activity are defined as the number of bicycles or cyclists at any given point or intersection. Low bike activity corresponds to 3 or less bicycles/cyclists. Medium bike activity is 3-10 bicycles, and high activity is 10 or more bicycles.

For cyclists, the bike level was overall low in the city center. Despite well-marked bicycle lanes that are separated from traffic, cyclists do not use the existing bicycle infrastructure near the city center. This was consistent across both site visits.

Outside of the immediate commercial center, low pedestrian activity was observed at all intersections, apart from Sycamore Street and Commerce Drive where medium pedestrian activity was recorded. This POI is located on a block with the Decatur Library and Recreation Center where public facilities and the designated municipal land use correspond to the pedestrian presence here. Despite collecting data in residential areas, mixed-use development and commercial centers, there were overall very few pedestrians out, most of whom were walking dogs or exercising. In this case, these pedestrians do not have a destination and are not attempting to access amenities or commute. Decatur is not pedestrian-friendly, and most people who do walk do so out of necessity (exercise).

Similarly, bike levels were low at all POIs, with the exception of the intersection at E. College Avenue and E. Trinity Place where it was medium activity. This outlier to cyclist activity is explained by the fact that this intersection connects Agnes Scott College to Decatur's downtown, and all cyclist traffic is funneled through this intersection. Despite this intersection being a major byway for bicycles and despite the diverse land use that surrounds this intersection (educational, commercial and mixed-use development) in different directions, there are not many cyclists. Street design and its implications on mobility explain the low cyclist traffic here.

Overall, very few cyclists were observed during site visits. Although Decatur has made a visible effort to cultivate a bikeable community, its residents are not utilizing this infrastructure.

Street Design

Decatur has multiple major roads radiating from Downtown Decatur. These roads connect different neighborhoods of the city together and link Decatur to other population centers in the Atlanta area. Clairemont Avenue runs north and links the city to North Decatur, Emory University, and North Druid Hills. College Avenue and Howard Street take traffic from Downtown Decatur to Downtown Atlanta to the west and Avondale Estates and Interstate 285 to the east. Candler Road runs south from Downtown Decatur to East Lake and Plantersville. Finally, Ponce de Leon Avenue connects Decatur to Atlanta's eastern intown neighborhoods and Midtown Atlanta, and to the east it runs to Scottdale, Interstate 285, and Clarkston.

Due to the street grid and pedestrianization of Decatur Square, there are no direct north-south roads that run through Downtown Decatur and limited east-west connections. This means that drivers often take Commerce Drive and Trinity Place to go around Downtown Decatur, and during rush hour at 5:45 p.m. on a Thursday, intersections featuring these roads were the most congested. Of all the intersections we observed, Commerce Drive and Clairemont Avenue were the most congested, with high levels of cars turning left from eastbound Commerce Drive onto northbound Clairemont Avenue, as well as cars turning left from southbound Clairemont Avenue to eastbound Commerce Drive.

One notable feature of some major intersections in Decatur is that they are bisected by railroad tracks. This leads to two lights that are often very close to one another, causing cars to either block intersections or not be able to turn, increasing congestion and causing safety issues. At the intersection of College Avenue and E. Trinity Place many cars were stopped on the railroad tracks waiting for the light to change, and multiple cars ran a red left turn arrow. There were not many pedestrians crossing at this intersection, despite apartments and businesses being located on the north side of the intersection, and Agnes Scott College and more businesses being located on the south side.

Development Management Systems Analysis

The current zoning ordinance of Decatur is overwhelmingly Single-Family residential with a clearly defined central commercial district padded by institutional holdings. There is some mixed-use zoning along the eastern boundary of the city, but overall, very little integration between uses. The data provided by the City of Decatur's Zoning District Map illustrates the overwhelming presence of Single-Family zoning, with categorical differences in zoning referring primarily to differences in lot size and density. All General Commercial zoning is located to the north of College Avenue, with some Local Commercial in Oakhurst, a commercial village and neighborhood hub, to the southeast of the city. Current zoning limits the city to highly separated land-uses that could be barriers to future mixed-use development, especially along the College Avenue, one of Decatur's main thoroughfares and limits accessibility to essential resources outlined previously, such as MARTA stops and grocery stores, which are essential amenities for residents and considerations for potential future growth (City of Decatur, GA. (2024)).

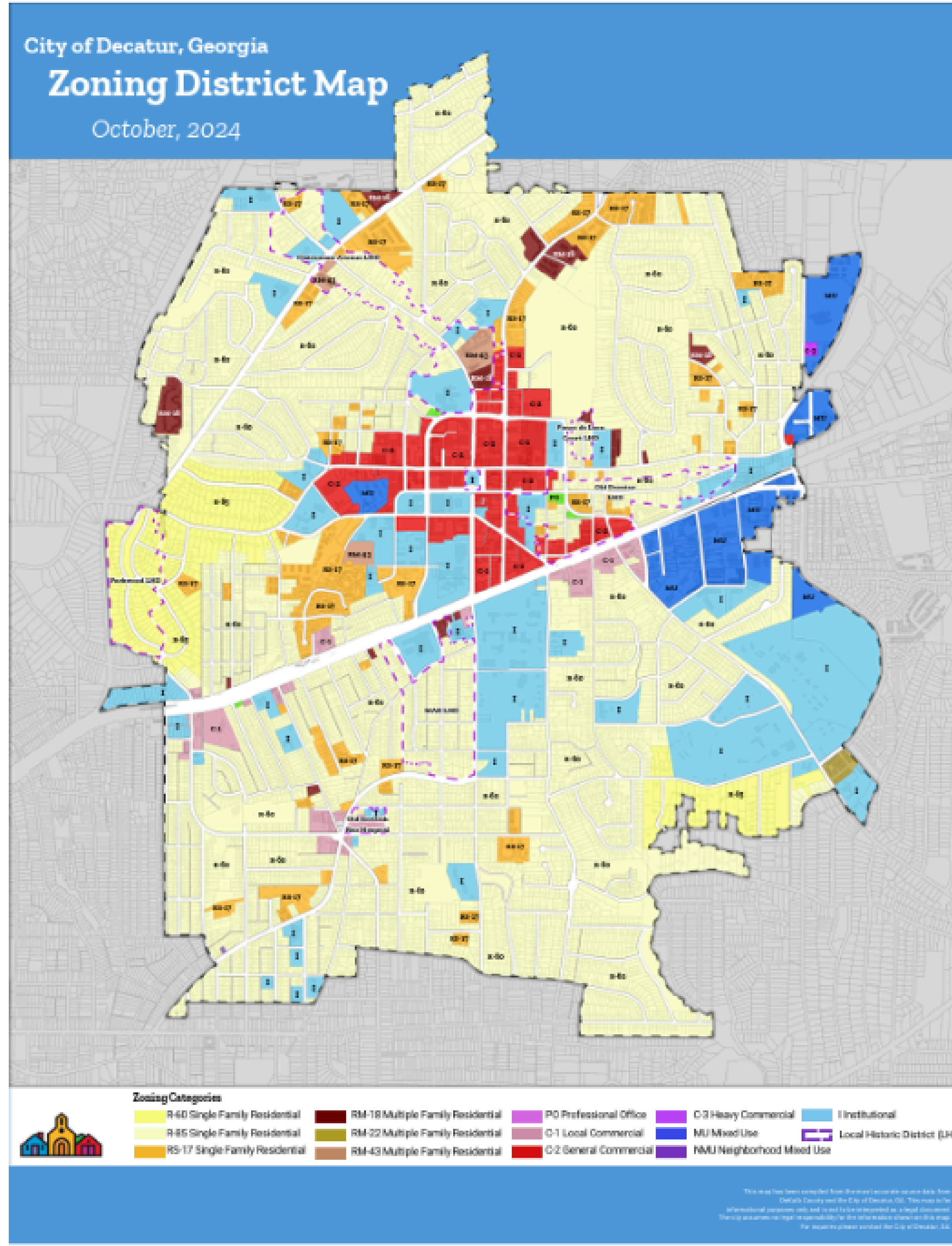


Figure 15

The Unified Development Ordinance (UDO) combines zoning, use standards, and environmental guidelines into a working document intended to specifically outline future growth and development efforts that align with the city's goals. Adopted in 2015 and regularly amended and updated, the UDO is a comprehensive resource for the city that guides much of its development and strategic growth (City of Decatur, GA. (2025)).

The UDO extensively discusses environmental protection, including the Stormwater Guidelines. Preserving existing tree canopies through the Tree Protection Section of the UDO is incentivized. Additionally, with Green Infrastructure and Low Impact Development (LID) practices, Decatur provides recommendations and quantifiable credits to assist with stormwater management. Decatur aims to prevent environmental disasters and maintain the city's integrated greenspace with extensive stormwater management frameworks, plans and codes.

The UDO also provides design specifications on streetscape design, with recommendations ranging from bench design to sidewalk constructions requirements. A Multimodal Transportation Impact Study gives insight on traffic patterns in the city and provides explicit criteria for growth thresholds and re-assessment efforts.

A Decatur Historical Preservation Ordinance is central to maintaining its five local historic districts. The Standards for the Treatment of Historic Properties under the National Historic Preservation Act guides local design principles, supplemented by Decatur's Design Guidelines (City of Decatur, GA. (n.d.)). This local document was created in 1997 and has been amended since. The Historic Preservation Commission is beholden to City Commission's approval, which limits their powers. There are accessible and explicit materials for residents to petition for historic designation within the city, although criteria outlined in the UDO must be met for consideration. Additionally, each historic district has a specific plan and codes for development. Historic preservation guidelines are extensive and elaborated across multiple documents across municipal platforms while maintaining the city's historic identity is an explicitly named priority for the planning department. The history of the area and its old structures are an asset to the city that they have painstakingly taken the effort to honor and protect. This provides potential limitations for modern redevelopment and up-zoning at it often undermines the historic appearance and quality of neighborhoods.

Decatur PATH and other municipal efforts have successfully created robust trail systems with protected bike lanes and well-marked corridors for pedestrian and cyclist use (PATH Foundation. (n.d.)). Walkability is an ongoing investment for the city that has specifically designated funding, partnerships, and implementation strategies.

The city utilizes Tax Allocation Districts (TADs) to invest in infrastructures as outlined in the Livable Centers Initiative outlined in the city's strategic and master plans (City of Decatur, GA. (2024, June 5)). The city has an application to actively expand their TADs to encourage additional development and redevelopment.

Affordable housing is a significant element of Decatur's development considerations due to their "missing middle" housing stock. The Decatur Housing Authority (AHA) works to provide Low Income Housing Tax Credit apartments, while the Homestead Exemptions for Homeowners, Property Tax Assistance Programs, Mandatory Inclusionary Housing policy (adopted in 2020), the Decatur Land Trust, and Affordable Housing Task Force initiative provide institutional and planning support in establishing affordable housing. Affordable housing is commissioned in every city's plan to achieve economic diversity and remains a top priority for the city due to high housing costs (City of Decatur, GA. (n.d.)).

Decatur's current development management system is extremely robust for its size and capacity limitations. Most of the city's efforts align with the national standard for Smart Growth Principles, defined by the Smart Growth Network (U.S. Environmental Protection Agency. (n.d.)). Current zoning has created a walkable, mixed-use center in Decatur, although it is limited by the lack of integration between residential and commercial zoning to create truly accessible and walkable activity centers. The city is working to provide robust housing options, particularly affordable housing for its residents, but is highly limited because Decatur is mostly developed and would require redevelopment and potential upzoning. Additionally, the city's robust documentation on historic preservation aligns them with the principle aimed at preserving natural and cultural resources.

The municipality and its development management resources and strategies is limited by the size of the city. Likewise, the city is predominantly developed, has a strong historic/cultural identity, lacks "missing middle" housing and has very segregated zoning, hindering their smart growth capacity. As a whole, however, Decatur has thoughtful and thoroughly developed development management strategies that are highly aligned with Smart Growth Principles.

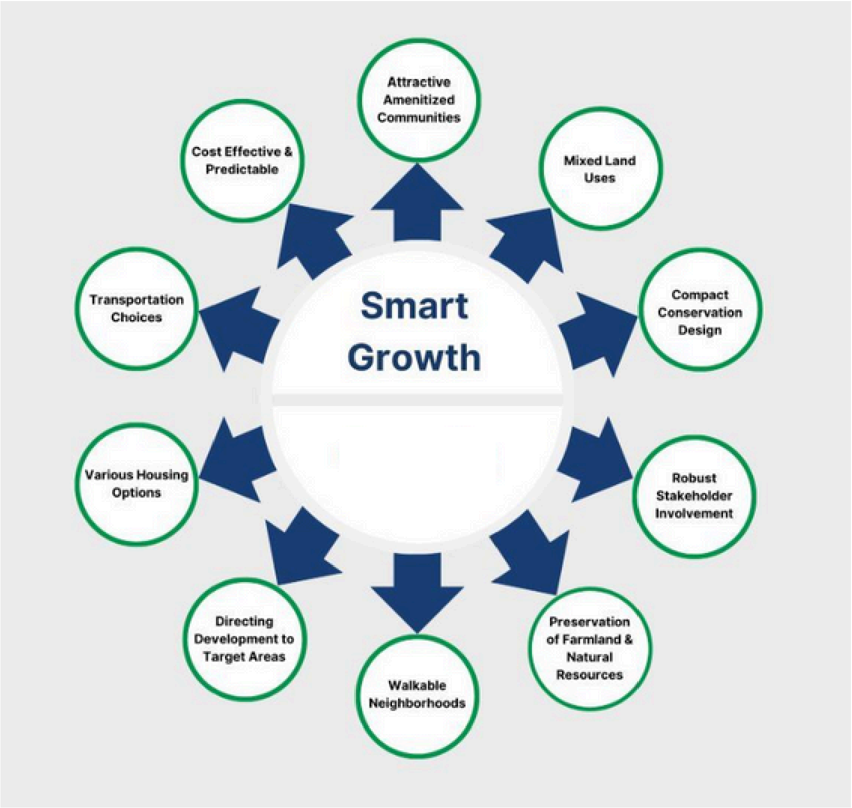


Figure 16

Implementation Strategy

Transportation

Many of Decatur’s greatest land use challenges are apparent from just a first visit to the city. Issues with current intersections and road designs have proven to be unsafe for users of all modes of transportation, and in extreme cases have led to fatalities (Whisenhunt, 2015). Much of these challenges are caused by the freight railroad track that bisects the city with multiple at-grade crossings. These crossings are often complicated and feature many conflict points for vehicles, pedestrians, cyclists, and trains.

There are a few smart growth tools that can directly address this issue. The first tool is grade separation of different modes, separating the railroad track from the roads. The primary intent of this tool is to improve intersection safety. Grade separation will allow for the easier implementation of other smart growth tools, such as traffic calming and increased space for pedestrian and bicycle infrastructure. This tools will improve walkability and bikeability in Decatur and help better connect the two halves of the city.

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The most difficult of these tools to implement is grade separation, as it is expensive and requires cooperation from CSX, the owner of the railroad tracks. However, MARTA is fully grade-separated in Decatur, and there are already multiple grade-separated freight rail crossings in the city, demonstrating that it can be done

New pedestrian and bike infrastructure will not be as difficult to implement, especially once there is additional right of way space opened up by grade separating the rail road tracks. On the north side, any new infrastructure will connect to a fairly extensive bike lane and sidewalk network, and on the south side there is a a large sidewalk network, but bike lanes are lacking. This will require expansion of the new bike network beyond just the target area near the railroad tracks.

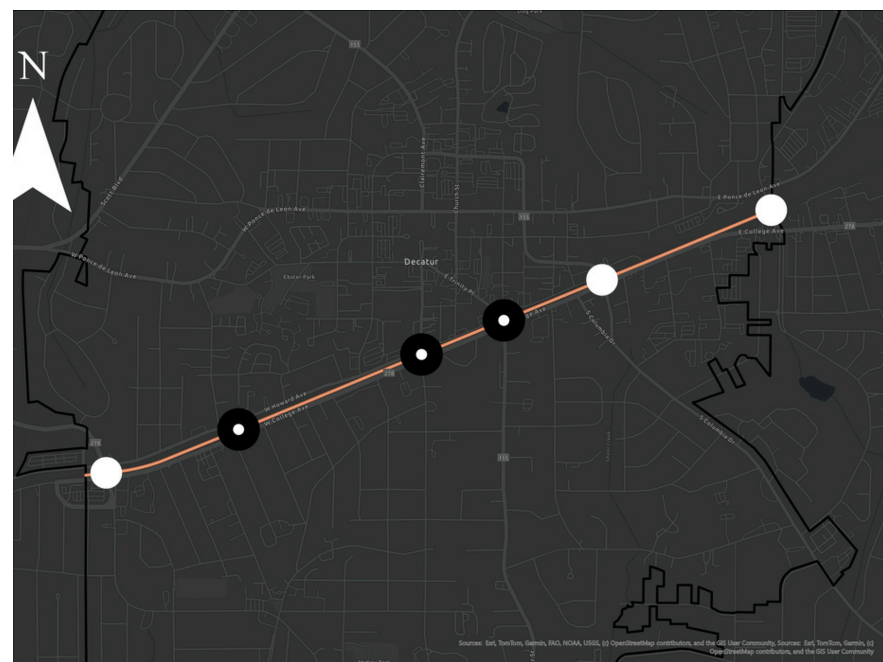
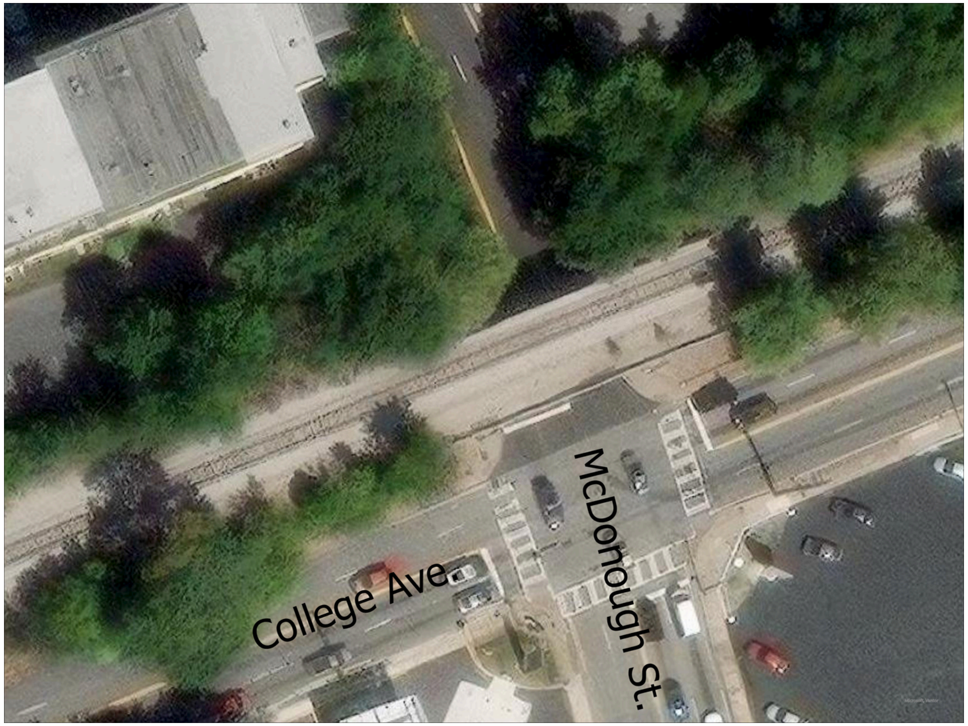


Figure 17

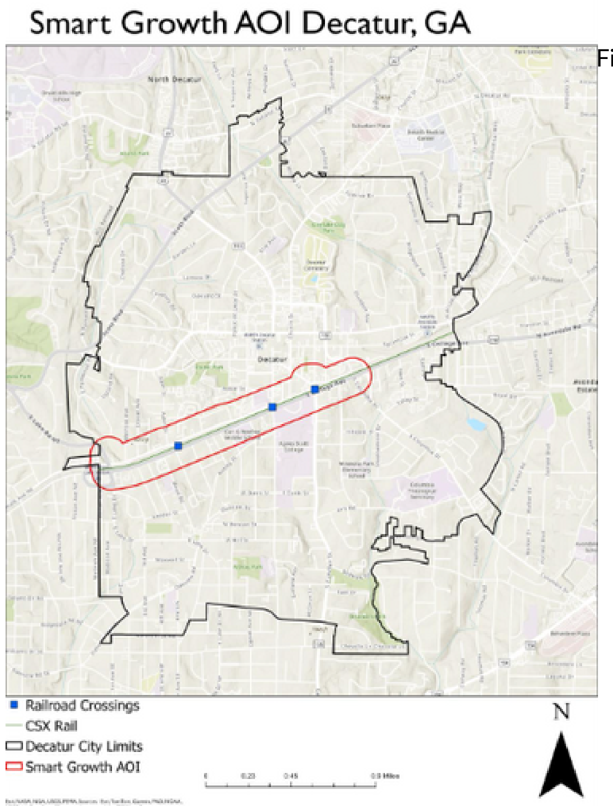
Housing and Zoning

Another issue in Decatur is the high cost of housing. In 2018, the proportion of homes that cost over $500,000 was nearly twice that of Atlanta (City of Decatur, 2018). For Decatur's zip code, 30030, the median sale price was around $600,000 (Redfin) . Smart growth tools to address Decatur's affordability issues are upzoning, new density, and potential infill development. This would attempt to address housing affordability by increasing supply to better meet demand. While the city could apply some upzoning policies across the city broadly, the most effective implementation would come from targeted development initiative. Upzoning along the newly grade-separated and improved freight rail track would create the potential for new housing in the center of the city along a new multi-modal corridor that features connections to multiple MARTA stations.

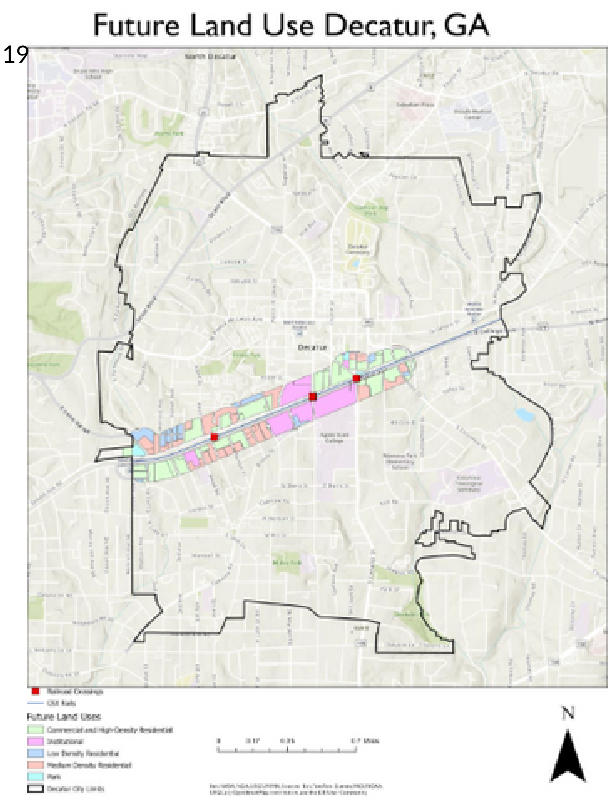


Smart Growth Scenario

The smart growth scenario we have chosen is a redevelopment plan surrounding the CSX railway going through Decatur parallel to Howard Ave and College Ave (Fg,?). This redevelopment would raise the CSX rail above grade, similar to other sections along the corridor. The objective of this scenario is to support a multi-modal transit network, increase affordable housing options, promote age-in-place, support vision zero, and transit-oriented development (TOD).



Figures 18 & 19



As seen in Figure 19 the land use surrounding the rail crossings are mostly medium to high density land uses. This provides more housing options across the smart growth area of interest (AOI). This also aligns with TOD plans the city of Atlanta promotes.

This map illustrates the walkability index of the AOI provided by the federal government. The scale is between 1-25, with 17-20 being a “good” walkability score and 20+ being an “excellent” score. Most of the AOI is below the good score with the Agnes Scott campus area having the highest walkability scores. Our plan looks to change this by increasing the overall walkability, bike ability, and pedestrian safety.

Walkability Index Decatur, GA

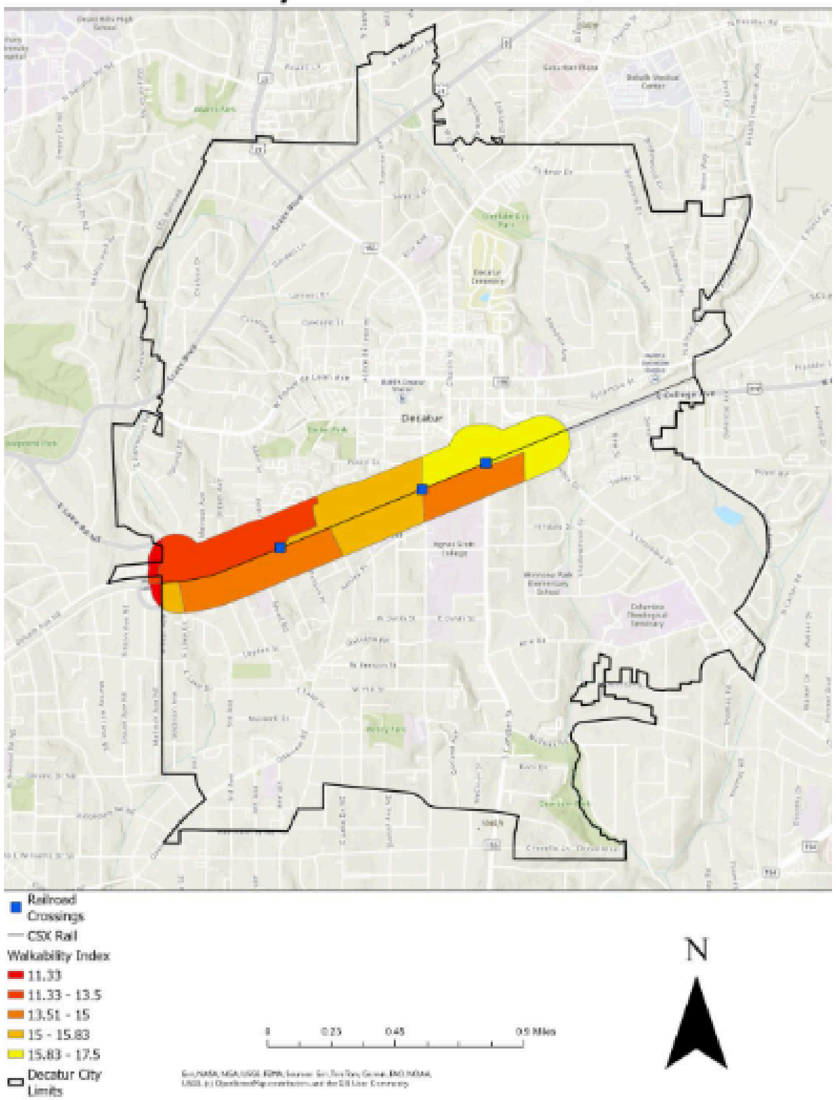


Figure 20

This map illustrates the walkability index of the AOI provided by the federal government. The scale is between 1-25, with 17-20 being a “good” walkability score and 20+ being an “excellent” score. Most of the AOI is below the good score with the Agnes Scott campus area having the highest walkability scores. Our plan looks to change this by increasing the overall walkability, bike ability, and pedestrian safety.

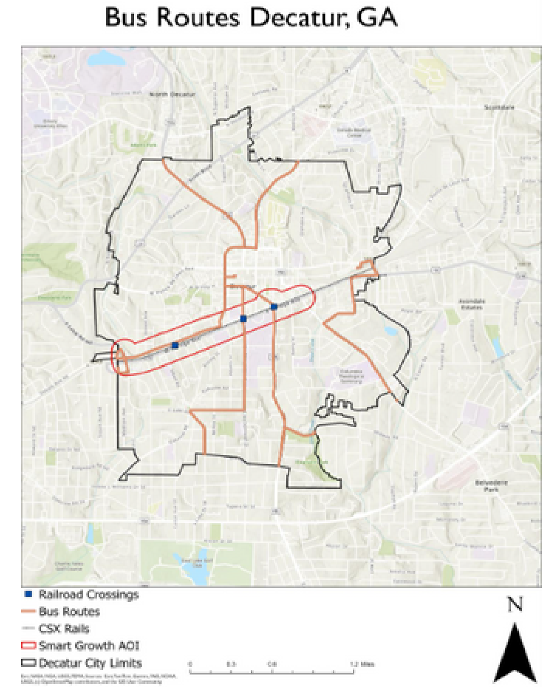
Achieving multi-modal transportation success requires multi-modal transportation options. Raising the rail above grade provides more room for these options. The PATH trail system is a bike system that runs through Decatur currently. As seen in Figure 23, there is a future path planned to go over one rail crossing and another finished path going along Howard Ave. The trail along Howard Avenue crosses an intersection adjacent to a rail crossing as well. Our smart growth plan would help create a safer connection between the paths while also promoting more opportunities for bike lanes. With a raised rail, the trails can be created off road or have better safety features with more room. There are also several bus routes along the AOI with two routes over the rail crossings (Figure 21). Raising the rail would create a smoother flow of traffic for the buses while also possibly allowing for more stops within the AOI.

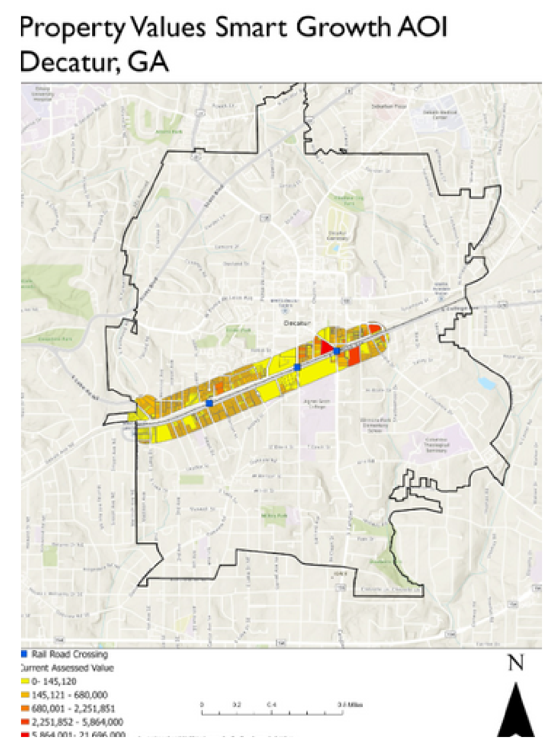
In order to provide more affordable housing within the AOI, there are several issues our plan must address. First, allowing upzoning within the AOI will create the possibility of higher density housing. Second, requiring new developments to provide certain levels of area medium income housing (AMI). This could look like a new 30-unit complex requiring 8 units at 30% of AMI, 6 units at 50%, and 4 units at 80% AMI. This policy change will be the most difficult part of the plan; there is much opposition to be expected. Lastly, acquiring housing funds could be another solution. This can be achieved via work with Atlanta Housing or Decatur Housing Authority. Another option is to apply for affordable housing grants via the AOI plan itself and create a new special affordable housing committee.

Age-in-place requires development to come to current residents. Our smart growth plan aims to achieve this via inclusionary strategies such as wider sidewalks, safer pedestrian access, supportive zoning, and better transit access. These strategies help long-term residents with amenities they need to stay stable. One specific policy change to increase pedestrian access is mandatory sidewalk sizes. This allows for better mobility around the AOI and can help with ADA access.

Vision zero is the goal of zero pedestrian deaths. This is a goal Georgia, Atlanta, and DeKalb County each have. In March of 2025, a pedestrian was fatally struck by a train along a crossing in the AOI. Removing the possibility of railway incidents will drastically reduce the possibility of pedestrian deaths.

Lastly, TOD is a crucial part of this smart growth scenario. TOD will determine if the other goals are achievable as it brings economic incentives. The AOI will be applied as a Tax Allocation District (TAD) district to help promote TOD. The AOI is also along several bus routes and will have increasing bike trails. The TAD incentivizes development along the corridor while also bringing in new amenities. Examples of this can be seen across Atlanta, such as the beltline.





Figures 21 & 22

As mentioned above, the PATH foundation has already worked within the AOI. Increasing their collaboration and presence will help with our objectives. PATH is a great private public partnership opportunity that Atlanta is very familiar with.

There are several initiatives to promote affordable housing at every level of jurisdiction. The state pathway would go through the Georgia Department of Community Affairs housing tax program. This program aims to provide tax credits to affordable housing. This includes mortgage payments for residents, tenants applying for tax credits, builders applying for tax credits, the usage of bonds to produce affordable housing, and more. The local option would be working through the Decatur Housing Authority. They work similar to the state level agency but focus specifically on Decatur. Notably, they aim to work on mixed-income housing which aligns with our AMI unit's strategy.

Another agency involved in this scenario is MARTA via their bus routes. MARTA recently announced that they are producing updated bus routes. This update to routes will remove two routes that run within the AOI. This will negatively impact almost every aspect of the smart growth plan. Ideally, communication between MARTA would need to occur immediately to prevent the closure of routes.

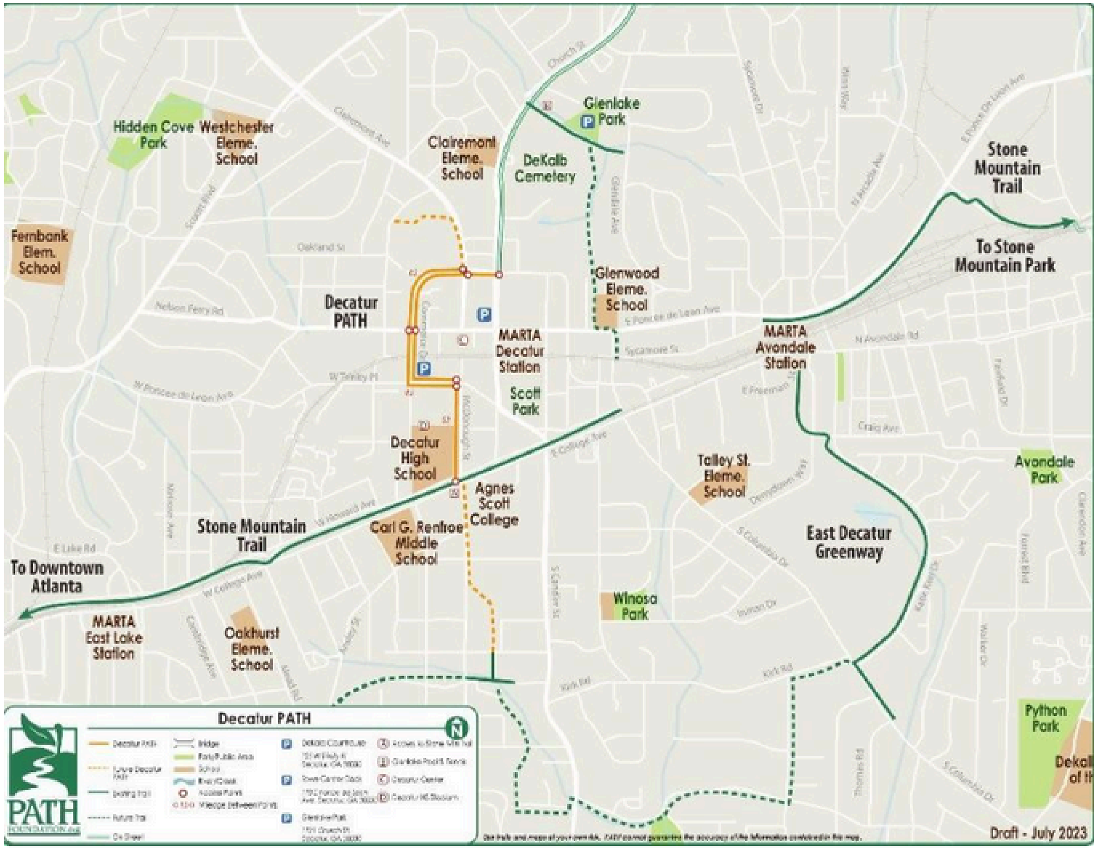


Figure 23

This smart growth scenario addresses smart growth land use principles through the objectives of the scenario. Our plan looks to increase density, provide mixed use opportunities, and encourage infill. Our plan does not address the history of Decatur or lean into historical developments.

Our scenario also addresses the mobility and transportation principles of smart growth. Objectives like TOD, increased walkability, and multi-modal mobility align with smart growth principles. The weakest, however, is multi-modal mobility as MARTA is planning on removing bus routes, leaving driving, walking, and biking as the only options for most of the AOI.

Lastly, our scenario addresses economic and environmental principles via dense developments, up zoning, and affordable housing plans. Our plan is the weakest in environmental protection, such as green space protection. Due to Agnes Scott College owning much of the land in the eastern portion of the AOI, there is little room for green space development. Moreover, with the rail being raised more green space will be available but this land will be reserved for PATH trails and will be covered by rail tracks.

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